

ONOMY

10

top global takeovers

Indian entrepreneurship took time to grow out of its socialist shell. While the early years saw only a Manu Chhabria taking on Shaw Wallace or R.P. Goenka buying Dunlop India, by the noughties, L.N. Mittal and Ratan Tata had the pick of global companies.



1 First Among Equals Ram Prasad Goenka

The RPG Group led by 'takeover wizard' R.P. Goenka made a series of acquisitions, kicked off by the Duncan buy in 1959 to the offshore holdings of tyre-maker Dunlop India in 1980. Ceat Tyres in 1982, the Gramophone Co. of India (now Saregama) in 1986, and Noida Power Company (NPCL) in 1992 among many others. The latest in the list was Canara Electric Controls in 2002. "I gamble only in companies," Goenka told INDIA TODAY in August 1984. Starting in the 1950s, the group patriarch and R.P. Goenka's father, K. P. Goenka, along with his three sons, made over 30 acquisitions in 25 years.

2 The Trend-setter Manohar 'Manu' Chhabria

Among the original corporate raiders of the country, Dubai-based Manohar 'Manu' Rajaram Chhabria picked up a large stake in Shaw Wallace in 1987 for Rs 35 crore, which remained mired in controversy and was finally sold to arch rival Vijay Mallya 20 years later. Spending over Rs 300 crore on acquisitions, he bought stakes in companies such as Hindustan Dorr-Oliver, Mather and Platt and Dunlop India. "Hardly any other Indian businessman has climbed to the top 10 league so rapidly." (INDIA TODAY, January 1989).